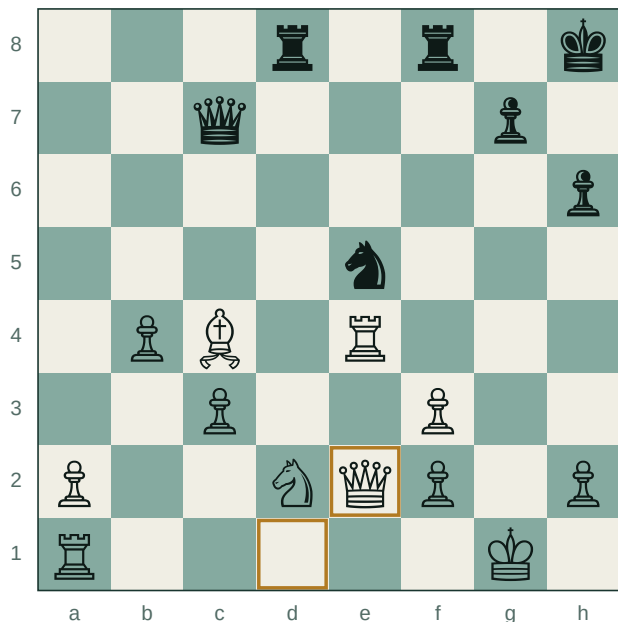


Capture the defender: Black, move 27

Capture the defender

Black to move



Previous move: 27.Qe2. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

27...Rxd2 28. Rxe5 Rxe2 29. Rxe2 Qxc4

27...Rxd2 The rook captures the knight on d2. Recorded reply: **28.Rxe5**.

28...Rxe2 The rook captures the queen on e2. Recorded reply: **29.Rxe2**.

29...Qxc4 The queen captures the bishop on c4.

At the end, nominal material is White 16 / Black 16 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +7. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +7: the balance goes from -7 to +0. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Do not assume a defender is unique. Another piece may take over its job, or the opponent may decline to recapture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Removing a key defender can transform a protected square into a winning entry. The defender's function explains why the first capture matters.

HOW TO LOOK

Identify the protected target, capture its essential defender, and calculate the follow-up after each plausible recapture.

The defending king is on g1. Geometrically undefended: rook on a1. Check for tactical protection.